Key Term: Orientalism

Text: Arrival (dir. Denis Villeneuve)

In *Orientalism*, Edward Said defines the term as a Western style for dominating, restructuring, and having authority over the "Orient," or non-Western others (Said 3). This system relies on constructing the East as exotic, irrational, and inferior to justify imperial control. In Denis Villeneuve's *Arrival*, the appearance of the Heptapods—alien beings whose language and purpose are initially unintelligible—echoes the logic of Orientalism. Western military and scientific institutions attempt to classify, decode, and ultimately control these beings, rather than understand them on their own terms. The film's **formal structure**, which defies linear temporality, challenges the viewer's reliance on rational, Western epistemologies. Louise's eventual mastery of the Heptapods' language requires abandoning imperialist logic in favor of vulnerability and relationality. The film's **visual motifs of fog, glass barriers, and translation** underscore the limits of comprehension imposed by Orientalist frames. In aligning alienness with unknowability and threat, *Arrival* mirrors Orientalist tropes, but by the film's end, it subverts them—presenting true communication as possible only through dismantling those frames. Said's framework reveals how imperial ideologies remain embedded even in speculative futures, unless actively disrupted (Said 11).

Villeneuve, Denis, director. *Arrival*. Paramount Pictures, 2016.

Said, Edward W. *Orientalism*. Vintage Books, 1979.

Key Term: Diaspora

Text: Shani Mootoo, "Out on Main Street"

Stuart Hall argues that cultural identity in a diasporic context is not fixed or essential but is instead a "production," always in process and shaped by historical displacement and hybridity (Hall 222). This understanding of diaspora—as a lived contradiction between origin and present—resonates powerfully in Shani Mootoo's "Out on Main Street." The story's queer narrator navigates both racial and sexual marginalization, feeling alienated from mainstream Canadian society and rejected by the South Asian community for their gender expression. Through the **use of Creole-inflected first-person narration**, Mootoo formalizes the speaker's fractured sense of belonging and the dissonance of existing between communities. The text resists offering cultural resolution, instead presenting identity as multiple and negotiated—mirroring Hall's theory. The narrator's experience reveals how diaspora does not simply involve relocation but entails an ongoing, daily negotiation of selfhood, often in the face of surveillance, policing, or rejection. Diaspora, in Mootoo's rendering, is not a bridge between two cultures but a space of tension and survival. Hall's theory of identity as performative and historically contingent helps us read the narrator's voice as both an assertion and a questioning of belonging (Hall 225).

Mootoo, Shani. "Out on Main Street." *Out on Main Street and Other Stories*, Press Gang Publishers, 1993, pp. 19–28.

Hall, Stuart. "Cultural Identity and Diaspora." *Identity: Community, Culture, Difference*, edited by Jonathan Rutherford, Lawrence & Wishart, 1990, pp. 222–237.

Key Term: Militarized Refuge

Text: Yen Lê Espiritu, "The Endings That Are Not Over"

Yen Lê Espiritu defines *militarized refuge* as a condition in which war and refuge are not opposites, but part of the same empirical process; refugees are "rescued" by the same nation-states that displaced them through war (Espiritu 2). In her chapter "The Endings That Are Not Over," Espiritu uses **interwoven scholarly analysis and personal narrative** to show how the Vietnam War's legacy persists in the lives of refugees and their descendants. Her use of **fragmented form and nonlinear storytelling** resists dominant U.S. narratives that treat war as an event with a clear beginning and end. By embedding her family's story alongside state-sanctioned histories, Espiritu contests the erasure of structural violence in the refugee narrative. Militarized refuge, as a concept, reveals how refugees are positioned not just as survivors but as products of the empire—controlled, categorized, and contained. The U.S. offers refuge not out of benevolence, but to sanitize its own imperial actions. Espiritu's refusal to offer closure or healing echoes her

theoretical argument: that the trauma of militarized displacement is not finished, and that the war continues through the conditions of migration itself (Espiritu 9).

Espiritu, Yen Le. *Body Counts: The Vietnam War and Militarized Refuge(es)*. University of California Press, 2014.

Not Your Fantasy: Gender, Illusion, and the Orientalist Gaze in *M. Butterfly*

In M. Butterfly, David Henry Hwang subverts Western fantasies of the submissive Asian woman by using performance—embodied in Song Liling's gender deception and the play's metatheatrical structure—as a formal lens to critique imperialism, race, and gender. Through the trial framework, shifting narrative perspectives, and the blending of reality with illusion, Hwang exposes how Western imperialist fantasies are constructed and sustained by gendered and racialized power dynamics, particularly through Gallimard's willful blindness. By breaking down the Orientalist gaze, M. Butterfly shows how the empire survives by turning people into objects—and by erasing the ones it can't control.

Performance functions as both a theme and a formal strategy in the play, most notably through Song Liling's manipulation of Gallimard's Orientalist expectations. Gallimard, deeply influenced by Puccini's Madama Butterfly, seeks a "perfect woman" who is "submissive" and "modest" (Hwang 17), embodying the Western fantasy of the feminine East. Song exploits this fantasy, performing femininity to infiltrate Gallimard's affections and national secrets. Hwang's use of performance not only reveals the constructed nature of gender—echoing Judith Butler's theory of gender performativity—but also highlights how race and sexuality are similarly theatrical. The play's metatheatrical structure, where Gallimard narrates and reenacts his memories onstage, reinforces this idea. He declares, "I've always held a fantasy in my heart… My favorite opera," conflating memory with staged drama (Hwang 1). Hwang keeps reminding us that identity and story are performances. Gallimard isn't seeing reality—he's trapped in a script written by the empire rather than the lived truth.

The trial framework further intensifies the play's critique by situating Gallimard in a position of exposure and judgment. No longer the narrator in control, he is now subject to interrogation by the state—and by the audience. This shift destabilizes his narrative authority and allows Song's voice to intervene. Song's courtroom monologue directly challenges Gallimard's fantasy: "You thought you were buying a Chinese fantasy… but instead you bought a lie you helped create" (Hwang 81). The courtroom, as a literal and metaphorical space of reckoning, puts Gallimard on trial, but really, it's the whole imperial fantasy that's being exposed. His identity falls apart without it. His version of love depends on a racialized, gendered illusion, one that the trial shatters. Hwang's formal choice to shift perspectives and use direct address creates a layered narrative that implicates the audience in Gallimard's self-deception, forcing viewers to confront the seductive power of Orientalism and its storytelling.

Ultimately, M. Butterfly dismantles the imperialist gaze by revealing how it reduces the "Other" to a consumable fantasy. Gallimard doesn't love Song—he loves the version of her that fits his fantasy. It's all about control, not connection. This commodification mirrors colonial dynamics in which the East is feminized, exoticized, and consumed by the West. As Edward Said argues, Orientalism constructs the East as passive and knowable, serving the West's self-image (Said 6). Gallimard's refusal to see Song as a man is not a failure of perception but a refusal to relinquish imperial control over the narrative. His final act—committing suicide in the garb of Madama Butterfly—reverses the original opera's power dynamic but offers no redemption. Instead, it dramatizes his total submission to a fantasy he cannot survive without. Hwang thus critiques not only Gallimard's personal tragedy but also the broader cultural scripts that sustain the empire through narrative, performance, and desire.

Through its layered structure and provocative use of performance, M. Butterfly exposes the fragility of imperial fantasies and the violence embedded in racialized and gendered representations. Hwang's play reminds us that these illusions are not harmless—they are systems of power that shape who gets to speak, who is seen, and who is erased. By dismantling Gallimard's fantasy and reclaiming the stage for voices like Song's, Hwang turns theatre itself into a site of resistance.

Hwang, David Henry. *M. Butterfly*. Plume, 1989.
Said, Edward W. *Orientalism*. Vintage Books, 1979.